

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Saturday 14, 2022, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 8:30 a.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward II Councilor James Contois
Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
At-Large Councilor William Limoges
At-Large Councilor Lucas Beliveau- via phone
At-Large Councilor Matthew Mooshian
Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

John MacLean, Interim City Manager
Lisa Richmond, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Mayor Girard opened the public hearing, no one spoke, Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

CITY MANAGER’S REPORT

Mr. MacLean thanked the Mayor and City Council for the hard work and effort with respect to this budget. Mr. MacLean noted it has been an unusual past couple of years leading up to this budget. Mr. MacLean added COVID and its relief funds that are no longer received along with inflation had an influence on this budget. Last year there was a reduction in the proposed property tax rate totaling \$15.01, this reduction was made possible because of the COVID relief funding that is no longer received. With funding not available to be used in the same regard that rate changed to \$15.17. This year’s proposed rate is \$15.25. Mr. Maclean noted this rate reflects the inflation, and added this proposed budget involves bonds along with the increase to property tax.

Mr. MacLean added the possibility of increasing operations and incorporating costs of Human Resources. Mr. MacLean recognized there is a small number of people managing this organization, this resulted in hidden costs, but very important to maintain, recruit and keep salaries in line with the market. Mr. MacLean stated while this budget may have some challenges it is a responsible budget.

Director Richmond addressed the Council first by speaking on the tax rate. Ms. Richmond recalled the presentation that was sent out months prior relative to the Fund Balance and MS 535. The MS 535 is the document that auditors prepare for us based on our actual budget numbers. Ms. Richmond noted at tax rate setting time we have a foot in FY21 and FY22 because of this combination our tax rate was lower last year. Ms. Richmond added if she were to remove the \$650,000 of Federal funds that we received in FY21 our tax rate would have gone up \$0.86 cents, to a tax rate of \$16.03.

Ms. Richmond wanted to make note of a few individual budgets before starting. Such as the Police budget relative to their personnel costs. Sanitation budget- Ms. Richmond wanted to make a correction to a comment: Wednesday when the Transfer Station is not open there are Public Works employees who go around and clean garbage in the downtown area and clean-up some roadside garbage. This is a function of the Highway Department. As a way of saving costs, Public Works will haul the City Hall garbage instead of hiring an outside contractor. Ms. Richmond noted this is not reflected in the Sanitation budget but is reflected in the Highway Department.

Fire

Chief Burr presented the Fire budget. Councilor Koloski asked for clarification on the proposed CIP AES software project. Chief Burr clarified this is a \$10,000 CIP.

Mayor Girard discussed traffic lights and asked where we are at for a reserve for a traffic lights. Chief Burr explained; aside from the Washington St. quarter which included nine traffic control intersections, there are five other intersections that are aging. Elm and North intersection, North Hannover intersection, Summer/Pleasant St. intersection are the high priority. Chief Burr noted he thinks this is a CIP program, because one controller could expend the entire Fire budget. Mayor Girard asked Ms. Richmond how much is in capital reserve for this, Ms. Richmond explained the transfer has not happened yet, but currently there is \$3,978.78 and will have \$8,978.78 after the transfer.

A motion was made by Councilor Contois and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the Fire Budget for \$2,638,676.00.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 9-0

Airport

Chief Burr noted to the Council that the largest line item is gasoline, that is an inventory line item.

Councilor Koloski noted that the Fire Chief is the only employee at the Airport but there is no employee line item. However, in the Fire budget it is noted that sixty percent of the Fire Chief's time is related to the airport.

Mr. MacLean made note that over time Chief Burr has taken on the responsibility as Airport Manager. Mr. MacLean added the amount of time has not been recognized that the Chief puts into numerous projects relative to the airport. Adjustments have not been made in the budget to reflect this. Mr. MacLean noted this should be high on the priority list over the next several years to evaluate what we have for a need at the airport relative to the amount of time to offset the many projects and overall maintenance of the airport.

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Airport Budget for \$138,065.00.

Roll call:

Contois -yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - no

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes
Motion carried 8-1

Planning & Development

Director Merrill reminded Council that Planning and Development is a merged department that involves economic development, marketing promotion, website planning, boards and commissions, GIS, zoning, building and property maintenance codes, project management grant administration while also overseeing the TIFD.

Ms. Merrill noted that this budget is primarily staff and staff costs, and mentioned receiving about \$100,000.00 in revenue. There are new line items Ms. Merrill brought to the attention of the Council. Last year \$2500.00 was authorized for the AMTRAK work which has been added to the budget this year. Ms. Merrill added under building maintenance and repair a new line-item maintenance and repair contract cleaning.

Ms. Merrill explained another budget change in regards to software. Where in previous years it has been under equipment maintenance and repair contracted services. Software was moved to the Viewpoint line.

Ms. Merrill added a new item is under Capital Projects which is the match for the TAP grant that was applied for.

Councilor Koloski asked how the trash service was handled. Ms. Merrill explained every Wednesday morning the DPW takes the trash.

Mayor Girard asked why the part time budget dropped from last year. Ms. Merrill stated the part-time position was never filled, and there was significant turn over last year, four full time employees left last year. Ms. Merrill noted the staff that is on board now can handle the department.

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Councilor Limoges to tentatively approve the Planning and Development Budget for \$865,882.00 for the department request amount not including TAP grant.

Roll call:

Contois - no
O'Hearne - no
Stone - yes
Matteau - no
Koloski - no
Limoges - yes
Beliveau - no

Mooshian - no
Girard - no
Motion fails 2-7

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Contois to tentatively approve the Planning and development budget as is for \$1,051,985.00

Roll call:
Contois - yes
O'Hearne – yes
Stone - no
Matteau -yes
Koloski - yes
Limoges - no
Beliveau - yes
Mooshian - yes
Girard - yes
Motion carried 7-2

TIFD-Downtown

Ms. Merrill noted administrative fees, marketing, and capital lines were all transferred into maintenance and repair for the parking garage.

In this budget there is an M&R request for \$35,000.00. Ms. Merrill also recommended adding \$30,000.00 in capital reserve for future needs.

Councilor Koloski asked if additional decks can be added to the parking garage. Councilor O'Hearne asked why this is all being put on the taxpayers and asked if the City could have people pay for parking. Councilor Koloski wants information on paid parking, Councilor O'Hearne clarified wanting information relative to paid parking in the parking garage and downtown.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the TIFD Budget for \$710,850.00.

Roll call:
Contois - yes
O'Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 9-0

City Administration (Finance)/Finance/IT

Director Richmond explained this budget includes Central Collections staff, IT Staff, Finance Staff, it also includes two collective bargaining groups; Teamsters and the Clerical Union along with the Merit Plan employees.

Ms. Richmond noted the health insurance line has decreased costs based on current personnel and buy out options.

Ms. Richmond explained information systems is security phishing software, printers, security cameras, and any electronic equipment.

Ms. Richmond stated there is not a lot of change in the bottom-line cost compared to FY22.

Mayor Girard noted IT being tight staffed and other communities have outsourced their IT. Ms. Richmond explained how internal software solutions to assist the IT department are being looked into.

Mr. MacLean noted Lebanon had contracted services and then switched back to internal, and stated the City has two wonderful and dedicated IT personnel.

Councilor Limoges questioned if our computers could handle the new software program that is coming, Ms. Richmond explained the program is cloud based and the servers will not be hosted here and will be easier for remote sites to function.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the City Administration (Finance)/Finance/IT Budget for \$907,318.00.

Roll call:

Contois -yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes
Girard - yes
Motion carried 9-0

General Services

Ms. Richmond expressed that General Services encompasses all departments and noted our most significant change over the previous year were computer upgrades, services, and equipment. This line item includes 365 license agreement, every user will need an agreement which is an estimated \$26,000.00. Cisco network switches, routers and phone systems need to be upgrade is also part of the increase.

Councilor O’Hearne asked how much has been spent for legal from last year. Ms. Richmond stated \$173,232.88 was spent while the original budget was \$186,500.

Mr. MacLean explained the quality of service is high, and we don’t have a person here on staff.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the General Services Budget for \$988,090.00.

Roll call:
Contois - yes
O’Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Limoges - yes
Beliveau - yes
Mooshian - yes
Girard - yes
Motion carried 9-0

Communication 911

Chief Chase noted the objective of the Claremont Police Department is to provide citizens with a competent Police force and Communications Center.

During FY22 the Communication Center was able to maintain most of the staffing. There was a loss of a communications supervisor, and there was a retirement. The most recent employee was hired in 2021, while the longest staff member has been there for thirty-five years. Chief Chase noted the Communications Center is still struggling to find part-time employees. This will continue to be a struggle as the wages for these positions are not competitive. There are two

current part-time employees but both are limited on the amount of time they can provide to the center.

Chief Chase noted he is looking forward to the communication updates that are underway. Chief Chase explained there are no requested increases in this budget other than contractual obligations for payroll and benefits.

A motion was made by Councilor Mooshian and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the Communication 911 Budget for \$629,861.00.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 9-0

Police Department

Chief Chase stated the Police Department is a 24/7 agency tasked with a great number of responsibilities from the community, the department has a lot of hard-working employees doing the best they can while keeping this community safe. Chief noted these are great employees for the City of Claremont who often go above and beyond what they are paid to do.

Chief Chase noted the largest area of this budget is regular pay. The budget line item includes all full-time Union and Merit Plan employees. 25 Police Officers, 2 full-time civilian employees, and 4 part time civilian employees. There are currently 3 full-time Police Officer positions open. Chief Chase stated the budget truly reflects the staff that is current and does not expect to promote an employee to captain or any other position over the next year.

Chief Chase noted to the Council his continued efforts to seek grant funding.

A motion was made by Councilor Contois and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau tentatively approve the Police Budget for \$ 3,385,041.00.

Mayor Girard asked if there was any discussion, Councilor Stone wants to amend the motion by taking off \$125,000.00 off the bottom total cost. Councilor Contois does not accept the amendment.

Councilor Koloski reminded the Council that the Chief was not going to be responsible for this budget after his retirement.

Councilor Koloski shared concern for police department grants and hiring. Councilor Koloski wants to know how water and sewer is billed out and if this metered separately in Police Department and Court Building.

Councilor Koloski asked how many vehicles we currently have in our fleet. Chief Chase explained there are twelve vehicles, but only eleven that are in use. One vehicle is parked at the Department of Public Works, Chief Chase expressed the goal is to trade in five cars and replace them with four.

Assistant Mayor Matteau suggested taking one or two positions out of the budget to lower the tax rate. However, Assistant Mayor Matteau expressed not liking how the officers are working may extra hours a week and doesn't agree with taking any money out of this budget.

Assistant Mayor Matteau shared concern about hoe the reduction in positions will affect the COPS grant.

Roll call:

Contois -yes

O'Hearne - no

Stone - no

Matteau -yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - no

Beliveau - no

Mooshian - yes

Girard - no

Motion failed 4-4

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Councilor Limoges to tentatively approve the Police Budget reducing the budget by \$125,000.00 for a total of \$3,260,041.00.

Mr. MacLean asked Councilor Stone where does the \$125,000 come from. Councilor Stone stated this number is relative to staff and their benefits which would equal out to about 1 1/3 of a Police Officer.

Mr. MacLean asked the Council to look at the budget and come back at next meeting relative to the \$125,000.00 with what the impact would be.

Councilor Stone withdrew his motion; Councilor Limoges withdrew his motion.

Sanitation

Director Gleeson shared that the Transfer Station operates Tuesdays and Saturdays from 8:00 a.m. to 3:45 p.m. There are two full-time employees.

Mr. Gleeson noted the increase to budget on the regular pay line item is reflective of contract raises projected for next year.

Mr. Gleeson also noted the increase to municipal solid waste, recycling, along with construction and demolition. These increases are based on inflationary costs, for recycling Mr. Gleeson added with increased fees the department is hoping for more diversion.

Assistant Mayor Matteau asked when the new fee structure goes into effect and asked if these fee increases were factored into the revenue.

Ms. Richmond noted that the increase of fees will recover \$128,000.00

Assistant Mayor Matteau stated she wants this to be a neutral cost to tax payers.

Mr. MacLean stated this can be looked into and brought back on Wednesday the 25th.

Councilor Stone stated there wasn't a fee for recycling on the new fee schedule that was approved last week. Mr. Gleeson expressed a new line item was never added to the new fee schedule because there were never any charges for recycling.

Councilor Stone motioned to table the Sanitation Budget, no one seconded.

Mr. MacLean stated the RFP is out, pre-bid is scheduled for next Thursday, and the budget does not reflect any of this yet. Mr. MacLean noted there will be time to amend the budget after receiving this information.

Councilor Stone Shared concern for the \$44,000.00 we pay for hauling recycling.

Presented budget is \$236,321.00

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Sanitation Budget for \$150,000.00.

Councilor Stone stated he met with Mr. Tetu and did not find his business plan viable, and would not support it. Councilor Stone then suggested to table this budget until the next meeting on May 25th.

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to move the question of the previous motion to tentatively approve the Sanitation Budget for \$150,000.00.

Roll call:

**Contois - no
O'Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Limoges - yes
Beliveau - yes
Mooshian - yes
Girard - yes
Motion carried 8-1**

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Sanitation Budget for \$150,000.00.

Roll call:

**Contois - no
O'Hearne - no
Stone - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - no
Limoges - yes
Beliveau - no
Mooshian - no
Girard - no
Motion fails 3-6**

Mr. MacLean clarified with the Council to bring back as much information to keep costs neutral, and revenue up by any means to the next Council meeting on May 25th. Mr. MacLean also asked permission to engage Mr. Tetu in conversation.

Cemetery

Mr. Gleeson explained the Cemetery budget and noted the vacancy in cemetery staff.

Mr. Gleeson noted the fee schedule changes were made in overtime and that is reflected in this budget.

Mr. Gleeson shared the increases on water and sewer relative to making a loop system for the North and Main project.

Assistant Director Wadleigh made note that the pay rates for temp and seasonal work are very low on the Merit Plan which is making it hard to find employees willing to do this work.

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the Cemetery Budget for \$195,193.00.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 9-0

Streets and Roads (Highways)

Mr. Gleeson shared the Streets and Roads Budget with the Council, and noted increases for fuel, contracted cleaning services which were not in the budget last year, along with vehicle and equipment M&R; there is a 7% increase due to inflation and delay time on equipment.

Assistant Mayor Matteau shared concern for paving not in the budget this year.

Mr. Gleeson expressed the potential use of bonds. Assistant Mayor Matteau expressed concern for the principle of the bond that would be used for paving, Assistant Mayor Matteau stated she views paving as an operational cost, and doesn't think using a bond for paving is good management.

Mr. MacLean noted using the bond for paving may be a good idea and asked the Council to stay open to it.

Councilor Stone, and Councilor Limoges are also not in favor of using a bond for paving.

The Council would like the City Manager to bring back information on what options we have for bonding, and find money in our budget in various forms instead of bonding. The Council would also like information on a hybrid model to bring back at the next meeting on May 25th.

No Motion was made.

Parks

Former Director Brislin shared that the Parks and Recreation department oversees 500 acres of park land, 10 parks, and is home to the Stevens Athletic Fields. Mr. Brislin expressed his former department plays a big role in economic development into community.

Mr. Brislin expressed the Disc golf course is another great asset in the community. Mr. Brislin noted the tennis courts are not up to par at Moody Park and have been closed for years.

Mr. Brislin Discussed working with the school district to move the tennis courts to Veteran's Park where the old pool was. Mr. Brislin shared the school district is willing to help, but nothing definitive has been put in place.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Parks Budget for \$414,656.00.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 9-0

CSB Community Center-Recreation

Former Director Brislin stated the Community Center is a great asset to the community, and open approximately ninety-six hours per week. All programs are run through this budget. Mr. Brislin shared there are approximately thirty active employees, including front desk staff, lifeguards, and fitness instructors. Five full-time staff members are shared between both budgets

and that includes the Director, Superintendent of Parks and Facilities, Superintendent of Programs, a Center Coordinator, and Maintenance employee.

Mayor Girard pointed out that the budget appears to be increased considerably but stated there was an offsetting revenue line item. Mr. Brislin explained this is for equipment replacement such as replacing treadmills and exercise bikes.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted discussions take place from year to year about the Community Center relative to tax-payers who don't use this center are carrying a lot of the cost. Assistant Mayor Matteau asked if any thought has been given to raising rates of members, expanding hours, babysitting, or other proposed options.

Mr. Brislin has been working with the Parks and Recreation Advisory Board members on ideas to bring in other revenue, as for the rates Mr. Brislin expressed after coming out of the pandemic it did not feel like it was the right time to raise the rates.

Mr. MacLean questioned if extending the hours of the facility has been discussed, Mr. Brislin shared the most significant issue with extending the hours is staffing.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the CSB Budget for \$1,363,641.00.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - no

Stone - no

Matteau -yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - no

Beliveau - no

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 5-4

Municipal Complex (Maintenance)

Mr. Willette joined Council to answer any questions relative to Maintenance. Councilor Koloski asked if the rents and leases that come in such as Opera House, and the court are extended Maintenance City services. Mr. Willette explained there is income from the court lease, and some funding is received from the Opera House.

Ms. Richmond stated this may need to be looked into if shows increase at the Opera House.

Mayor Girard asked if the part-time contracted cleaning services is a long-term agreement, Mr. Willette stated this was a yearly contract, but would prefer going back to hiring a twenty hour a week employee.

Mayor Girard asked if the Clock Tower repairs were able to be looked at. Mr. MacLean explained this was not doable due to the high cost.

Mr. Willette stated there are some areas in the Clock Tower that need to be addressed but these repairs can be done through the building M&R.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Mooshian to tentatively approve the Municipal Complex Budget for \$459,693.00.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes

Girard - yes

Motion carried 9-0

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 2:35 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call:

Contois - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Limoges - yes

Beliveau - yes

Mooshian - yes
Girard - yes
Motion carried 9-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro
Clerk to the Council